Summer Reading is Killing Me

By Jon Scieszka

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: Actor 1: Joe, Fred, Frankenstein
Actor 2: Uncle Joe, Narrator, Giant, Sam, Red Queen, Character from Lord of the Flies, Devil, Teddy, Anna

JOE: **(Pg 6-7)** This is going to be impossible to explain. But I think I know what happened. My life has not been the same since my uncle Joe gave me THE BOOK *(An elderly Uncle Joe hands Joe a very precious book)* – a book like no book I've ever read before or since. It's a time-warping book. I know. I know. You're saying to yourself . . . .

NARRATOR: "What's with this guy? He probably still believes in the Easter Bunny and the Tooth Fairy."

JOE: I didn't really believe it myself. Then Sam and Fred and I opened THE BOOK. We have been chased by a woolly mammoth, turned into mummies and nearly suffocated by one very nasty-smelling giant. *(Giant burps a disgustingly foul burp and Joe responds) (Beat)* And once we go to another time, the only way to get back to our time is to find THE BOOK in **that** time . . . So anyway, there we were – sitting in my room the very first day of summer vacation . . . We were trying to be careful. We really were!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 2: *Summer Reading is Killing Me by Jon Scieszka*

FRED: **(Pg 8-9)** No more classes, no more books. No more teachers' dirty looks!

SAM: *(pointing to a book on the bookshelf)* Can we please promise not to open THE BOOK and get sucked into some time-travel trouble like we always do?

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FRED: I'm with you. We don't have to open any books!

SAM: Well, now that you mention books . . . I was thinking we might get an early start on this list.

FRED: Summer reading list? Are you crazy. This is vacation.

SAM: *(Reading aloud from the list)* Each student must read four books during the summer and fill out the attached study guide for two of them. The list has Hatchet, The Phantom Tollbooth, The Hoboken Chicken Emergency . . .

FRED: **(Pg 10-12)** *(grabs the list from Sam and sticks it in a book from the shelf)*

JOE: *(stares, aghast at the bookshelf)* Forget it you guys! You don't have to decide!

SAM: What do you mean we don't have to decide?

JOE: *(pointing to the bookshelf)* We have about three seconds before this green mist leaking off my bookshelf decides for us! *(The boys are engulfed in a green mist)*

FRED: How did that happen? I didn't do nothing.

SAM: Anything. You didn't do anything except put our summer reading list inside THE BOOK!

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FRED: **(Pg 16)** *(looking around cautiously)* We can't be in a book. That only happens in movies. There is no way I am going to spend my summer vacation in a book.

SAM: This is very weird, but quite possibly true. What if story characters are real? What if they have a life we just don't know about.

JOE: **(Pg 20-21)** Oh no . . We are in huge trouble. If this means what I think it means, all of the characters from every book on the summer reading list are mixed up here. And none of them are in their books where they're supposed to be. The librarian is going to kill us.

SAM: What if the Red Queen says, "Off with Ramona's head!?"

JOE: What if the Twits mess up Wayside School?

SAM: What if the Tripods take over the Little House on the Prairie? We have to get everyone back in the right book!

JOE: **(Pg 22-23)** We have to get back THE BOOK and take the summer reading list out of it before anything happens!

TOGETHER: THE LIBRARY!

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JOE: **(Pg 25-27)** We took off. We passed old houses, an alley, a street lined with shops and in just a few minutes we were at the corner of the park. Just then we heard a wild yelling and the sound of stomping footsteps behind us. *(Actor 2 provides sound effects)* Dracula was dragging Winnie-the Pooh in a headlock. Mr. Twit was breaking Harold's purple crayon. Twenty different bad guys from twenty different books were chasing, hauling and pushing all kinds of characters up the steps of a big old brick building.

FRED: **(Pg 28)** *(Reading the sign on the building)* Hoboken Public Library!

SAM: The one building in Hoboken that we need to get into is packed with every bad guy from every book ever written! *(The boys sneak into the library)* **(Pg 33)** *(in a whisper)* I see it, but I don't believe it. That's Mrs. Twit tying up Marry Poppins and Encyclopedia Brown.

JOE: That's Frankenstein holding Pippi Longstocking

FRED: They even got Mother Goose.

RED QUEEN: **(Pg 34-35)** Off with their heads!

CHARACTER FROM LORD OF THE FLIES: Kill the pig! Cut his throat! Bash him in!

JOE: I don't know what's going on here, but it doesn't look good. Let's sneak up those stairs and start looking for THE BOOK – quick! *(they begin up the stairs but are stopped by a commanding voice)*

DEVIL: You three boys. What book are you from? Come here now!

FRED: Is that who I think it is?

JOE: Do you know any other red guy with two horns and a pointed tail? *(to the Devil)* **(Pg 38)** We're the Time Warp Trio!

DEVIL: *(Looking at his list)* I have no Time Warp Trio!

RED QUEEN: **(Pg 38)** Off with their heads!

SAM: We're probably not under Time Warp Trio because we're actually a series . . .

FRANKENSTEIN: *(Groaning and making a move toward them)* Series . . . bad!

THE DEVIL: **(Pg 39-40)** *(Stroking his beard)* Maybe you can make this easier on all of us. What we are doing here is separating the good characters from the bad characters. The bad characters stay here and take over any story they like . . . And the good characters go

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there . . . to be crushed by those huge stacks of books and wiped out of stories forever! So . . . are you good characters . . . or bad characters?

JOE: **(Pg 42-43)** Then the door with LIBRARIAN written on the glass slammed open with a bang.

TEDDY: What is going on out here?!

FRED: A . . . . a . . . teddy bear?

TEDDY: **(Pg 44)** That's Mr. Bear to you, kid! *(The boys try to hold in their laughter)* This is exactly what I'm talking about. Just because I'm a teddy bear, I get no respect. Everyone thinks I'm soft and huggable and stupid! What exactly is the holdup here? Why isn't everyone being crushed?

DEVIL: **(Pg 45-50)** We were . . .uh . . I was just . . . checking in these three characters.

TEDDY: Characters? Hah! They aren't characters from a book. These are three kids. In fact, they are just the kind of readers I get no respect from – wise-guy boys! Throw them in the crusher now! *(Frankenstein lumbers to do his bidding)*

JOE: *(Screaming)* Now just one minute! Look, Mr. Teddy – I mean Mr. Bear. It is true that we are not the biggest fan of teddy bear books . . . but crushing all of the good characters from every other book is not going to solve anything. *(trying to sound very adult and reasonable)* Just look how dumb these books sound without their main characters.

SAM: There are giant holes in every story. *(he picks up a book and reads)* "Run run run as fast as you can. You can't catch me, I'm the blankety blank?

JOE: *(grabbing another book)* The Hoboken Chicken Emergency is just The Emergency

FRED: *(picking up a third book)* Sylvester and the Magic Pebble is And the Magic Pebble.

TEDDY: Aww, that is so sweet. You are worried about all the poor little books. Well, don't worry. The new titles of those books will be The Teddy Bear Emergency, Teddy Bear and the Magic Pebble and The Teddy Bear Man! *(Raises his arms and laughing a crazy villain laugh at the ceiling)* Frankenstein in Wonderland . . . Green Eggs and Dracula.

FRANKENSTEIN AND THE RED QUEEN: *(Cheering)* Ted-dy! Ted-dy! Ted-dy!

TEDDY: **(Pg 58-59)** Crush those boys now!

FRED: We'll never make it to the door. Quick. Up these stairs!

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JOE: We charged up the steps two at a time. Captain Ahab, the Devil and a red-golden dragon climbed after us. We reached the top landing, blocked by the stack of books that had been meant to crush us. *(To the boys)* Get back here and push! *(They give a massive shove. Frankenstein and Dracula are buried in the avalanche)*

SAM: **(Pg 60-61)** Nice shot!

TEDDY: You are making me angry!

JOE: We couldn't hold out for much longer. I looked around for a way to escape. Stairs blocked. Window too high to reach. That's when I saw our salvation! A thin blue book covered with silver stars and moons. A folded list stuck out of the middle. THE BOOK!

TEDDY: **(Pg 62)** I will squash you! I will flatten you like the bugs you are! No one ruins my plans. I will be the most famous character in every story!

FRED: Give me some cover . . .
(He does an amazing maneuver, in slow motion, to leap over the bad characters and grab the book; Sam and Joe continue to pelt the characters with books as a distraction) (Fred dramatically opens the book and removes the reading list – holding it aloft as if were Excalibur)

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(the boys are engulfed in a green mist and land back in Joe's bedroom, surrounded by books. Fred has THE BOOK in one hand the reading list in the other. They shake themselves and immediately begin thumbing through the books)

JOE: **(Pg 67-69)** Mary Poppins, Charlotte, Frog and Toad – everybody's back! *(the boys laugh in relief)*

ANNA: Ahem! *(the boys freeze)* Ahem! I don't really want to know what you are doing. I just wanted to ask you if you have any ribbon I can use for my *(She holds her teddy bear aloft)* teddy bear . . .

TOGETHER: *(Cowering in fear)* NOoooooooo!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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